

Psalms 20

Trust Beyond Chariots

Some trust in chariots, and some in horses

KJV · Standalone study handout

1 · THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 *The LORD hear thee in the day of trouble; the name of the God of Jacob defend thee;*
- 2 *Send thee help from the sanctuary, and strengthen thee out of Zion;*
- 3 *Remember all thy offerings, and accept thy burnt sacrifice; Selah.*
- 4 *Grant thee according to thine own heart, and fulfil all thy counsel.*
- 5 *We will rejoice in thy salvation, and in the name of our God we will set up our banners: the LORD fulfil all thy petitions.*
- 6 *Now know I that the LORD saveth his anointed; he will hear him from his holy heaven with the saving strength of his right hand.*
- 7 *Some trust in chariots, and some in horses: but we will remember the name of the LORD our God.*
- 8 *They are brought down and fallen: but we are risen, and stand upright.*
- 9 *Save, LORD: let the king hear us when we call.*

2 · CONTEXT

Psalms 20 is a corporate prayer for the king before battle, likely sung by the people over him, asking God to answer, remember his offerings, and grant the desire of his heart, before pivoting to a communal declaration of trust in the name of the Lord rather than in military hardware. Henry notes it functions almost as a liturgy of blessing that trains a nation's confidence away from visible resources toward the invisible, sufficient help of God, anticipating Psalm 21's answer of victory already given.

3 · VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1-4

Corporate intercession for the king: may the Lord hear him in the day of trouble, send help from the sanctuary and Zion, remember his offerings, and grant the desires of his heart and fulfil all his purposes—prayer offered on someone else's behalf, not self-focused.

Verse 5-6

The people anticipate rejoicing in his salvation and setting up banners in the name of God; assurance follows—"Now know I that the Lord saveth his anointed"—help coming from God's holy heaven with the saving strength of His right hand.

Verse 7-9

The psalm's famous confession: "Some trust in chariots, and some in horses: but we will remember the name of the Lord our God." Those who trust in mere resources are brought down and fall, while those who trust the Lord stand upright. A closing prayer asks God to save the king and hear the people when they call.

4 · MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

Genuine national and personal confidence rests not in visible military or material resources but in remembering and calling on the name of the Lord, who alone determines who stands and who falls.

Application for life today.

Identify your own "chariots and horses"—the resources, credentials, or safety nets you quietly trust more than God. Practice interceding for leaders the way this psalm models, praying specifically for their hearts' desires and purposes to align with God rather than only for outcomes you want. Before your next "day of trouble," rehearse verse 7 as a decision, not just a feeling: "we will remember the name of the Lord."

5 · REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no "right length" answers—honesty before God is the aim.

1. What are your personal “chariots and horses”—resources you trust more readily than God?

2. How could you intercede more specifically for leaders in your life, following the pattern of verses 1–4?

3. What would it look like this week to consciously “remember the name of the Lord” before a stressful moment rather than after?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, *Commentary on the Whole Bible* (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).